

# Business Insights Report

Superstore Sales Dataset | Data Analytics & BI - Task 1

## Overview

This report summarizes key findings from cleaning, exploring, and querying the Superstore sales dataset (300 orders). Analysis was performed using Excel (cleaning & pivot tables), SQL (aggregation queries), and Power BI (interactive dashboard). Headline figures: **Total Sales: \$77,903.81** | **Total Profit: -\$499.03** | **Total Orders: 300**.

## 1. Which Region Generates the Highest Sales?

**Central** is the strongest-performing region, generating roughly **\$35,739** in sales — nearly double the next closest region. West follows at approximately \$20,124, then East at \$13,440, with **South** trailing as the weakest region at just \$8,602.

| Region  | Total Sales |
|---------|-------------|
| Central | \$35,738.81 |
| West    | \$20,123.53 |
| East    | \$13,439.85 |
| South   | \$8,601.62  |

## 2. Which Category Is Most Profitable?

**Office Supplies** is the only consistently profitable category, contributing roughly **+\$1,420** in profit. Both **Furniture** (-\$1,414) and **Technology** (-\$504) are operating at a net loss overall, despite Technology generating the highest sales volume (41.9% of total sales). This is a critical disconnect: the category selling the most is not the category making money.

| Category        | Total Profit |
|-----------------|--------------|
| Office Supplies | +\$1,419.52  |
| Technology      | -\$504.47    |
| Furniture       | -\$1,414.09  |

## 3. Are Discounts Affecting Profit?

Yes, clearly. Average profit per order is healthy at **\$50.62** with no discount applied, but it declines sharply as discount levels rise. Once discounts exceed **20%**, average profit turns **negative** (-\$12.69 at 30%, -\$46.98 at 32%). Discounting is directly eroding margins beyond this threshold.

| Discount | Avg. Profit / Order |
|----------|---------------------|
| 0%       | \$50.62             |

|     |          |
|-----|----------|
| 10% | \$7.10   |
| 20% | \$18.31  |
| 30% | -\$12.69 |
| 32% | -\$46.98 |

#### 4. Which Month Performs Best?

**September** is by far the strongest month, generating approximately **\$27,665** in sales — nearly triple the next-best month (December, ~\$15,649). Sales are notably weak from May through August, before a strong upward run into the final quarter (Oct-Dec). This suggests a clear seasonal pattern, with September likely tied to back-to-school or fiscal planning purchases, and year-end buying lifting Q4 overall.

#### 5. Key Recommendations for Management

- **Cap discounts near 20%.** Profit turns negative beyond this point — consider revising discount policy, especially for Furniture and Technology, where margins are already thin.
- **Re-evaluate Furniture and Technology pricing/costs.** Both categories are unprofitable despite strong sales (especially Technology). Investigate supplier costs, shipping costs, or excessive discounting as root causes.
- **Double down on Office Supplies.** It's the only reliably profitable category — consider expanding this product line or using it to cross-sell against lower-margin categories.
- **Investigate the South region's underperformance.** With sales less than a quarter of Central's, South may need targeted marketing, more sales reps, or a review of regional pricing/logistics.
- **Plan inventory and staffing around the September peak.** Ensure adequate stock and fulfillment capacity ahead of this seasonal spike to avoid stockouts and capture maximum revenue.